

Listening into Writing

Climate Change



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

Listening



- You are now going to a podcast in which the BBC journalist Marianna Spring talks to the climate scientist Professor Michael Mann about the modern disinformation war.
- The podcast is around 17 minutes long.
- As in previous weeks, listen to the podcast and take notes.
- Use your notes to write a 200-400-word summary.

Note:



Remember, you do not have to note everything down – just the main ideas.

This week, there is more than one speaker so you may have to use different subjects in your summary:

- “Michael Mann” (the climate scientist)
- “Marianna Spring” (the journalist)
- Or simply, “The podcast”



Climate change deniers

BBC NEWS | WORLD SERVICE

Notes:



- The first 3.30 minutes are an introduction. Professor Mann talks about coming face-to-face with the impacts of climate change in Australia in 2019/20 and having to counter misinformation claiming the bushfires were all due to arson, and not climate change.

You could include this information in your summary, but it is not critical.

- From 3.30 until 6.11, the podcast describes how Professor Mann has long been a target of climate deniers. In 1998, he published a graph known as the 'hockey stick graph' which showed global temperatures were rising and human activity was to blame. Attacks included allusions to his ethnic background and being sent an envelope with white powder. Now, as the impacts of climate change have become increasingly present, there has been a decline in outright denial of climate change. Instead, opponents have started using "softer, more insidious" tactics.

Again, you could include this information in your summary, but it is not critical.

Notes:



- From 6.45 until 10:07 the podcast describes four tactics of denial:
 - Delay – climate change is real but it's not that much of a problem
 - Division – getting climate advocates to fight with each other so they don't speak with one voice
 - Deflection – getting people to focus on their own carbon footprint, deflecting their attention from necessary policy changes
 - Doomism, Doomongering, Despair mongering – the idea that it's too late; there's nothing we can do

This is important. Your summary should include what the four tactics are.

- From 10:07 to 11.17 the podcast discusses why understanding the disinformation landscape is important. It says one reason is COP26 (regarded by many as our last best chance to avoid the negative effects of climate change).

You could mention this but it is not critical.

Notes:



- From 11:17 to 14:11 Marianna Spring talks about disinformation on social media. She says social media has been weaponised to abuse climate activists. She cites the experiences of a 17-year-old climate activist Theresa Rose-Sebastian. Michael Mann says this is worrying as it is an attempt to make sure young climate activist do not participate.

You should include something about disinformation and social media, but you do not need to go into a lot of detail.

- From 14:11 to 15:08 Michael Mann talks about how Russia, as a state actor, has used social media to advance a pro-fossil fuel agenda.

You could use Russia as an example of a state using social media to spread disinformation.

- From 15:08 until the end. Mann concludes by saying our secret weapon is the moral authority of our children; the focus should not be on science, economics, policy or politics, but our ethical obligations. He concludes by saying he is optimistic.

You need to summarise how the podcast concludes so should include some information about this.